

Maintaining ecological integrity at Ontario Parks | Quinte News

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Ecological Integrity is something Ontario Parks takes very seriously. Ecological Integrity refers to how “natural” an area is. That naturalness consists of three main components: the structure, composition, and the function. The structure of an ecosystem includes all the living and non-living parts, from the rocks, to the water, plants, wildlife, and everything in between. The composition is how many native species are in the area or the biodiversity. The functions of the ecosystem are the natural processes that support biodiversity including the natural predator prey relations and water cycles. Shannon Taylor, Chief Park Naturalist at Sandbanks Provincial Park says when all three are in good shape, the park is healthy and can thrive. “Ecosystems are always going through ebbs and flows, whether it be day by day or year by year, but when they are functioning the way we intend them to, when all of those pieces are working well, the area is considered healthy, so in Ontario parks, we’re really passionate about connecting visitors with the land, while also protecting the environment for generations to come, and making sure that all three of those pieces are working well together.” Taylor says Ontario Parks works to protect natural and cultural features across the province but also those specific to each park. “So at Sandbanks this means that we’re protecting the world’s largest freshwater bay mouth barrier dune system, an incredibly important area to protect. So, while people are out visiting parks and enjoying their time in these parks, whether they’re hiking or paddling or lounging on the beach, that they are all supporting ecological integrity.” The bay mouth barrier dune system divides West Lake from Lake Ontario. Throughout the park there are stretches of post-and-rope along Outlet Beach and Dunes Trail, barriers to keep visitors along designated paths and away from sensitive dune areas so they can function naturally. Even a few steps off-trail can harm the fragile vegetation that grows there and holds the dunes together. “So the dunes are always shifting and moving, whether it be from wind and wave action. So, there’s never a time where you’ll visit Sandbanks and have the duty to look the exact same twice. But our pioneer species, like maram grass and poison ivy, are doing what they can to keep root of that area, so they stabilize the sand and keep it all from drifting all over the county.” Staff and volunteers, including school groups, plant maram in the spring and fall to help trap some of that sand and make it a bit more of a hardy soil. And once those plants begin to die off, they offer more nutrients in the soil to the plants that come next. Staff are also planting some native trees, milkweed and other grasses. Invasive species removal is also important to give native species the space and sunlight they need to thrive. “While we do work to get rid of garlic mustard, we’re also working on buckthorn and white sweet clover and many other species throughout the park. So, again, super, super labour intensive to do all that removal and to do the planting, but we are always very grateful for the help, and these projects help

to keep the environment healthy at Sandbanks.” Volunteers also aid staff with invasive-species removal including the annual Buckthorn Removal Weekend put on by Friends of the Sandbanks each fall. Taylor says they’ve been seeing fantastic results in the Lakeview Trail area near Lakeshore Lodge with a big reduction in the non-native shrub. She adds that across the province, there is research being done in the parks that helps to strengthen long-term conservation of the land and species that live there. There are also some educational opportunities including what Taylor calls discovery programming which helps people of all ages connect with nature, and learn about the species that call our parks home. Visitors play a huge role in maintaining and enhancing the ecological integrity of the province’s parks. While exploring parks, stick to designated trails and campsites to help protect sensitive areas. You can also practise “leave no trace” by packing out everything you bring in. Taylor hopes to see lots of visitors enjoying the parks across the province this summer and reminds us to keep in mind some of those practices to keep up the ecological integrity of our parks for years to come.